8.2(b) Humanism in Literature

The idea of humanism was first expressed in literature. The humanists were critical of medieval ideas and institutions and criticized them satirically in their writings. They argued that man was endowed with reason and the ability to attain true knowledge and greatness. **Petrarch** (1304-1374 A.D. (C.E.)) was the first to adopt ideas of classical humanism in his works and is therefore called the **Father of Humanism**. **Dante**, influenced by the classics, wrote *Divine Comedy.* **Machiavelli** wrote a political treatise called *The Prince*. In this book, he wrote about the virtues that a ruler should possess. He declared that a ruler should be Lion and Fox in one. For him, the end was more important than means. Erasmus (1466-1536 A.D. (C.E.)), known as the *Prince among Humanists,* wrote *In Praise of Folly,* a satirical work on the activities and rituals of the Church. Sir Thomas More of England wrote *Utopia*, a satire on the political evils of his time. Cervantes of Spain wrote *Don Quixote,* another satire on medieval chivalry and valour.

Humanism

The idea of humanism was a central feature of renaissance. It laid emphasis on human dignity and nature. In the medieval period, man was considered a mere agent of the God on earth to do his will. Renaissance humanism promoted the view that humans are endowed with attributes that are to be used to achieve greatness. It turned the gaze of the people from the other world to this world, from spiritual world to material world. The focus shifted from life after death to life in this world.

8.2(c) Impact on Art

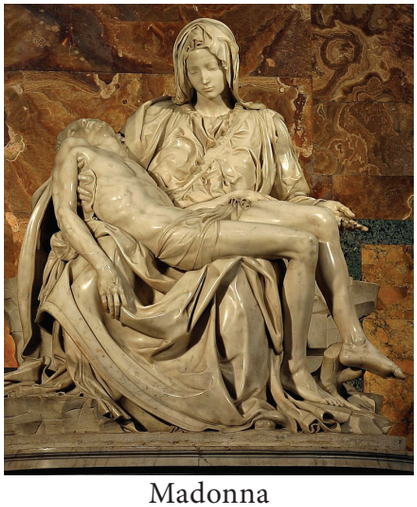
Renaissance paintings and sculptures were realistic and naturalistic. They improved over medieval paintings and sculptures which were stylized, unrealistic and two dimensional. They portrayed natural landscapes, human anatomy, emotions and ideas.



Mona Lisa

In the field of art, great artists like **Leonardo da Vinci, Michelangelo and Raphael** dominated the scene and produced some of the finest artistic works. Leonardo da Vinci (1452-1519 A.D. (C.E.)) was a versatile genius. He was a painter, sculptor, architect, military engineer, anatomist, and poet. His paintings of *Mona Lisa (La Giaconda), The Last Supper* and *The Virgin on the Rocks* are illustrious examples of his talent.

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Madonna

Michelangelo (1475-1564 A.D. (C.E.)) was a painter, sculptor, architect and poet. His marble sculpture of David depicts the youthful strength and energy of the giant slayer. He is also famous for his paintings in the ceilings of the Sistine Chapel in Rome. Raphael (1483-1520 A.D. (C.E.)) painted beautiful *Madonnas* (Virgin and the Child). His painting of *the*

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